



TOK

*Thinking beyond class.
Reflecting beyond answers.*

Ján Gonda
TOK Teacher

TOK Handbook

IB DP Súkromné gymnázium Česká



School: Súkromné gymnázium Česká

Programme duration: September 2026 - March 2028

Teacher: Ján Gonda, TOK Teacher

Visual summary	3
1 Course description	4
2 What TOK develops	4
3 Course structure	5
4 TOK concepts and the knowledge framework	5
5 TOK across the curriculum	6
6 Assessment at a glance	6
7 TOK exhibition	7
8 TOK essay	8
9 Academic integrity & responsible use of sources	9
10 Timeline overview	9
11 Student responsibilities	9
12 Support for success	10
Sources	10



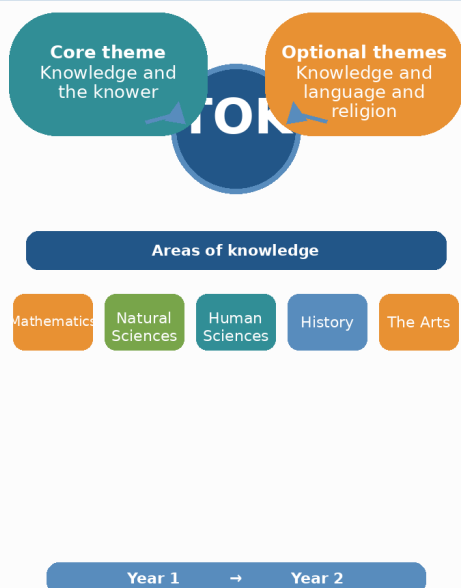
Visual summary

These school-created diagrams summarize the course structure, assessment sequence and key concepts described in this handbook.

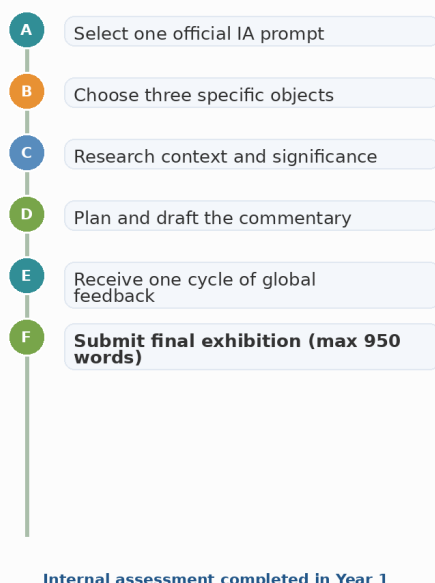
Theory of Knowledge Visual Summary

School-created diagrams aligned with the TOK handbook

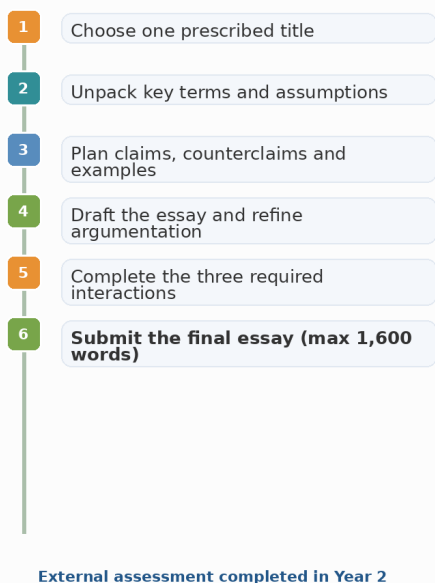
1. TOK course overview



2. TOK exhibition process



3. TOK essay process



4. Twelve TOK concepts





Figure 1. Visual overview of the TOK course, the exhibition, the essay and the 12 key concepts.

Course duration	TOK exhibition	TOK essay
100+ hours taught across two school years.	Completed, marked and internally recorded in Year 1.	Developed through required interactions and submitted in Year 2.

1 Course description

Theory of knowledge (TOK) is a core element of the Diploma Programme. It gives students structured opportunities to explore the nature of knowledge and the process of knowing through concrete examples drawn from subjects, daily life and the wider world.

In TOK, students ask knowledge questions, compare different perspectives and reflect on how knowledge is constructed, shared, challenged and justified. Throughout the course, they use the knowledge framework - scope, perspectives, methods and tools, and ethics - to examine how knowing works in different contexts.

At Súkromné gymnázium Česká, TOK is planned as a two-year, concept-driven and inquiry-based course. The school sequence is designed so that students complete the exhibition in Year 1 and the essay in Year 2, while developing strong links with their other DP subjects throughout the programme.

Key features of the course

- TOK is taught across two school years with at least 100 hours of class time.
- The curriculum is organized around the core theme, two optional themes and the five areas of knowledge.
- The 12 TOK concepts and the knowledge framework are used repeatedly across all units.
- Students are expected to keep a TOK journal and participate actively in discussion, reflection and peer feedback.

2 What TOK develops

TOK aims to help students become more reflective, critical and responsible knowers. Through the course, students learn to:

- frame and refine knowledge questions
- evaluate evidence, arguments and interpretations
- recognize the influence of language, perspective, culture and values on knowing
- compare how knowledge works across different disciplines
- communicate ideas clearly and responsibly
- reflect on the ethical dimensions of knowledge

The course also supports international-mindedness and the IB learner profile by encouraging students to engage with multiple viewpoints, uncertainty, dialogue and responsible judgement.



3 Course structure

The TOK course follows the sequence below.

Period	Main focus	Allocated time
DP1 Semester 1	Introduction to TOK and course concepts; core theme: Knowledge and the knower; optional theme: Knowledge and language	17 weeks
DP1 Semester 2	Optional theme: Knowledge and religion; TOK exhibition preparation and final submission	18 weeks
DP2 Semester 1	Areas of knowledge: Mathematics, Natural Sciences, Human Sciences, History; cross-AOK synthesis	18 weeks
DP2 Semester 2	Area of knowledge: The Arts; TOK essay process and final submission	11 weeks

4 TOK concepts and the knowledge framework

Across the course, students work with the following 12 TOK concepts.

Evidence	Certainty
Truth	Interpretation
Power	Justification
Explanation	Objectivity
Perspective	Culture
Values	Responsibility

Students also use the knowledge framework in every major block of the course.

Element	Guiding question or focus
Scope	What counts as knowledge here? What are the aims, boundaries and limits of this area?
Perspectives	Whose knowledge is involved, and how do culture, context, values and communities shape it?
Methods and tools	How is knowledge produced, tested, communicated and justified?
Ethics	What responsibilities, risks and consequences are connected to this knowledge?



5 TOK across the curriculum

TOK is not treated as an isolated subject. The course is intentionally linked to other DP subjects through a shared planning routine.

- Each subject unit includes a short TOK moment connected to one subject knowledge question.
- Teachers and students identify 2-3 TOK concepts that best match the unit.
- The TOK link explicitly uses at least one element of the knowledge framework.
- Students produce a short output such as an evidence check, certainty statement, assumption spotlight or perspective reflection.

Examples of cross-curricular support

- Before each major TOK block, the TOK teacher consults subject departments to gather current examples, case studies and objects.
- Students are encouraged to bring examples from their subjects into TOK discussions and writing.
- At least one cross-curricular highlight is planned each semester to make TOK links visible across the Diploma Programme.

6 Assessment at a glance

The assessment of TOK consists of two components. Both are marked out of 10 using global impression marking.

Component	Weighting	When it is completed	Who marks it
TOK exhibition	33%	Year 1	Teacher-assessed; externally moderated by the IB
TOK essay	67%	Year 2	Marked by IB examiners



School sequence

- The exhibition is completed, marked and internally recorded in Year 1.
- The essay is developed and completed in Year 2.
- The school assessment calendar is coordinated with EE and CAS to support balanced student workload.

7 TOK exhibition

The TOK exhibition is the internal assessment component of the course. Students create an exhibition of three objects, or images of objects, connected to one official IA prompt.

- Students select one official IB IA prompt.
- Students choose three specific objects with clear real-world contexts.
- Students produce one typed commentary of up to 950 words in total.
- The final submission includes the chosen prompt, images of the three objects, the commentary, and appropriate citations and references.

Teacher support is limited to one draft feedback cycle. Teachers may provide global advice for improvement, but they do not edit the student's work.

Recommended Year 1 workflow

- Phase A - Launch: introduction to IA prompts, assessment instrument and the object-context-TOK link.
- Phase B - Object bank and proposal: students shortlist prompts and propose possible objects.
- Phase C - Research and planning: students investigate provenance, context and possible lines of argument.
- Phase D - Draft and feedback: one full draft is submitted and receives global feedback.
- Phase E - Finalization and exhibition event: students submit the final single file and may share their work in a class or school exhibition.
- Phase F - Marking and standardization: the teacher uses the official assessment instrument and stores the work for moderation procedures.

Illustrative object possibilities

- A Slovak passport used at an airport border-control desk - useful for exploring authority, classification, identity and what counts as official knowledge.
- A screenshot of a generative-AI chatbot answering a history question - useful for examining reliability, interpretation, authorship and justification.
- A museum label placed beside a reconstructed artefact - useful for discussing curation, perspective, context and how institutions shape knowledge.



- A Covid-19 vaccination certificate or public-health poster - useful for linking expertise, evidence, trust and the communication of scientific knowledge.
- A calculator or spreadsheet output that changes because of rounding or formatting - useful for thinking about certainty, representation and mathematical knowledge.
- A school academic integrity policy or exam rubric - useful for discussing standards, values, responsibility and how communities regulate knowledge claims.

These are examples only. In the actual exhibition, students should choose objects that are specific, well-contextualized and closely connected to one chosen IA prompt.

8 TOK essay

The TOK essay is the external assessment component of the course. Students write a response to one of the six prescribed titles released by the IB for the examination session.

- Maximum length: 1,600 words.
- Students respond to one prescribed title only.
- Footnotes and appendices are not used for extra argumentation.
- The essay must include clear examples, developed argumentation and appropriate references.

Required teacher-student interactions

- Discussion of the set of prescribed titles.
- Discussion of the student's initial exploration of the chosen title.
- Comment on one full draft only, recorded on the TOK essay Planning and Progress Form (TK/PPF).

Recommended Year 2 workflow

- Phase A - Essay skills and AOK grounding: building arguments with examples, perspectives and implications.
- Phase B - Title selection and initial exploration: choosing a title and discussing early planning notes.
- Phase C - Drafting and one feedback cycle: full draft, global teacher feedback and revision.
- Phase D - Final submission: polished final essay uploaded

Illustrative past prescribed titles

- "To what extent are areas of knowledge shaped by their past? Consider with reference to two areas of knowledge."
- "There is no reason why we cannot link facts and theories across disciplines and create a common groundwork of explanation." To what extent do you agree with this statement?
- "There is no such thing as a neutral question." Evaluate this statement with reference to two areas of knowledge.
- "The task of history is the discovering of the constant and universal principles of human nature." To what extent are history and one other area of knowledge successful in this task?



These titles are included only to demonstrate the style of past prescribed titles. Students always write on one of the six titles issued for their own examination session. > according to IB procedures.

9 Academic integrity and responsible use of sources

Academic integrity is embedded across the full two-year TOK course. Students are expected to act honestly, reference sources accurately and use objects, examples and evidence responsibly.

- All claims, quotations, images and source-dependent ideas must be acknowledged appropriately.
- Exhibition objects must be specific, authentic and clearly placed in their real-world contexts.
- Essay references must be accurate and consistent.
- AI tools, if allowed by school policy, must be used responsibly and never as a substitute for the student's own thinking and writing.

What this means in practice

- Keep clear notes on where ideas, quotations and examples come from.
- Do not invent or misrepresent sources, evidence or object contexts.
- Use feedback to improve your work, but do not allow anyone else to rewrite it for you.
- When in doubt, ask before submitting.

10 Timeline overview

The timeline below summarizes the intended sequence of learning and assessment.

Stage	Main activities
DP1 September-January	Introduction to TOK, course concepts, core theme: Knowledge and the knower
DP1 January-June	Knowledge and Language; Knowledge and Religion; exhibition preparation and finalization
End of DP1	Exhibition completed, marked and internally recorded
DP2 September-January	Mathematics, Natural Sciences, Human Sciences, History, cross-AOK synthesis
DP2 January-March	The Arts; essay planning, drafting and final submission

11 Student responsibilities

Students are expected to take ownership of their learning in TOK. This includes:

- keeping a TOK journal and bringing examples to class
- participating in discussion, seminar work and peer feedback



- meeting interim deadlines for exhibition and essay work
- maintaining accurate notes, references and source records
- approaching disagreement respectfully and thoughtfully
- reflecting on how TOK connects to other DP subjects

12 Support for success

Students are supported through regular class discussion, modeling, planning checkpoints, peer dialogue and structured teacher guidance.

- Classroom modeling of knowledge questions, argument structure and object analysis
- One draft feedback cycle for the exhibition and one for the essay
- Cross-curricular examples gathered from DP subjects
- A shared focus on claim-evidence-justification, perspective-taking and ethical reflection

A useful rule of thumb

- In TOK, stronger work usually does three things well: it stays specific, it explains why an example matters, and it reflects on knowledge rather than only describing content.

Sources

- Henly, Carolyn P., and John Sprague. Theory of Knowledge for the IB Diploma (Fourth Edition). Hodder Education / Hachette Learning, 2020.
- Theory of knowledge guide (first assessment 2022), as referenced in the school TOK course outline and assessment planning.
- School TOK course outline, Súkromné gymnázium Česká.
- School-created visual summary diagrams aligned with this handbook.